An Antarctic Island Looks Like a Skull, and Its Ice Is Telling a Story

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Seen from above, Vega Island in Antarctica looks like a grinning **skull** looking toward nearby Devil Island. Behind that spooky sight is a serious story about changing **glaciers**.

A rocky **peak** looks like an empty eye socket, a ridge along a **glacier** outlines the mouth, and a **glacier** forms the lower jaw.

NASA **satellite** images, taken by the Operational Land Imager aboard Landsat 9, show the island in March 2025 and again in October 2026. In March 2025, snow covered the land. By October 2026, large sections were free of snow, leaving darker **glacier** ice exposed.

Glaciologist Mauri Pelto explained that a warm winter in 2026, especially in June, helped cause the exposed ice. Little fresh snow built up, and some snow was lost through **sublimation**, when ice turns directly into water vapor, and strong winds.

The lack of snow could matter in warmer months. Fresh snow reflects sunlight, while darker ice absorbs more energy and may warm and melt faster. A thin cover of new snow would help in the short run, Pelto said.

Word Treasure

skull -- The bony part of a head that protects the brain and holds the face shape.
peak -- The pointed top of a mountain or rocky hill.
glacier -- A huge, slow-moving river of ice.
sublimation -- When ice turns directly into water vapor without melting first.
satellite -- A machine in space that takes pictures or sends signals back to Earth.

Background you need

A glacier is a huge mass of ice that moves very slowly over land.

Fresh snow is bright and bounces sunlight back, while dark ice soaks up sunlight and warms faster.

Satellites can photograph the same place at different times so scientists can compare snow and ice.

Break it down

WHO: Vega Island, its glaciers, and glaciologist Mauri Pelto.
WHAT: Satellite images show far less snow on the island in October 2026 than in March 2025.
WHERE: Vega Island in Antarctica, near Devil Island.
WHY: Warm winter weather left darker ice exposed, which may melt faster.

Why it matters

When ice in Antarctica melts faster, it can change sea levels far away, so watching snow cover there matters to everyone.

Test what you remember

1. What does Vega Island look like from above?

(A) A whale
(B) A mountain
(C) A grinning skull
(D) A star

2. What looks like an empty eye socket?

(A) A rocky peak called a nunatak
(B) A snowstorm
(C) A satellite
(D) A glacier

3. What did satellite images show in October 2026?

(A) No ice at all
(B) The island had vanished
(C) Large sections free of snow, leaving darker ice exposed
(D) More snow than in March 2025

4. What helped cause the exposed ice?

(A) Heavy rain
(B) A warm winter in 2026, especially in June
(C) A new road
(D) A volcano

5. Why does darker ice matter?

(A) It stops melting
(B) It absorbs more energy and may warm and melt faster
(C) It makes the island colder
(D) It reflects all sunlight

6. What would help in the short run, according to Pelto?

(A) Less sunlight
(B) A thin cover of new snow
(C) A bigger satellite
(D) More wind

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Mauri Pelto: Explained that a warm winter left ice exposed and said new snow would help in the short run.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):